destiny. Whatever it is, Tardi Beg seems to have been at ease, suspecting nothing, when Bairam got up to wash before the evening prayer. This was a signal to his men, who fell as one on Tardi Beg and killed him.

When Akbar returned that evening, Pir Muhammad brought him the news. Bairam had sent an equivocal apology with his deputy: 'He hoped that [Akbar] would approve of him with the glance of pardon so that other evil-doers might take warning.'[28]

If Akbar was unhappy or upset by the sudden execution of a familiar face, he said nothing. Besides, Bairam was busy planning a strike on Hemu; Tardi Beg was already old news. Any talk of him would be a distraction from the business at hand – getting Akbar an empire.

Nor was Hemu resting on his laurels. Having heard that the Mughals were planning to retaliate, he sent his artillery ahead to Panipat, and prepared to follow. Bairam, too, had dispatched an army of 10,000 men under Ali Quli Shaibani, an outstanding Uzbek warrior who would soon display his flair for battle. The Mughals weren't far from Panipat when Hemu's guns and cannons arrived. Immediately – with the reflexive speed that would become a hallmark of Akbar's own military strategy – Ali Quli Shaibani raced ahead with a small detachment of men, surprised the commanders guarding the artillery, and took it from them.

Hemu wasn't dismayed by the setback; instead, he left Delhi 'with consummate pride and great celerity'.[29] The distance from Delhi to Panipat is under 100 kilometres. Famine still held sway over the region, so there would have been little sign of life along the way, the fields untended or even unsowed as Hemu and the 'black mass of his army'[30] marched by. His cavalry alone comprised 30,000 'practiced horsemen',[31] Rajput and Afghan, and there were anywhere between 500 (Abul Fazl) and 1500 (Badauni) elephants, wearing bright armour, spears and daggers tied to their trunks, carrying musketeers and archers on their backs.

Never before had many of the Mughals seen these 'mountain-like and dragon-mouthed' creatures in such grand array. Abul Fazl's description catches something of the open-mouthed gasps of awe that may have filled the air as the two armies came face to face on 5 November 1556 upon the battle-weary plains of Panipat. How could a description of these 'rushing mountains be strung on the slender thread of words'? An elephant could